

cavalry, commanded by John A. McCausland, across the Potomac again. On the morning of July 30, the troopers rode into Chambersburg, Pennsylvania, demanding \$100,000 in gold as compensation for General David Hunter's burning of Virginia homes the previous month. When the ransom could not be produced, McCausland torched the town.



### **Chambersburg in ruins**

Hundreds of buildings were destroyed when, on July 30, 1864, Chambersburg, Pennsylvania, was torched by Confederate cavalry in retaliation for Union depredations in Virginia and failure to pay a ransom.

## **The Union response**

The North was incensed, as was General Grant, who summoned his pugnacious cavalry chief, Philip Sheridan. "I want Sheridan to be put in command of all the troops in the field," Grant declared, "with instructions to follow the enemy to the death."

It proved to be a pivotal decision. "Little Phil"—as the diminutive Sheridan was affectionately known—entered the Valley near Harpers Ferry in August at the head of the Army of the Shenandoah, nearly 40,000 soldiers strong. Encamped outside Winchester, Early marched and countermarched his heavily outnumbered troops, hoping the resulting dust clouds would create the impression of a much larger force. Sheridan bided his time, and struck on September 19.